

ESSENTIAL

US Tourist Visa (B-2) Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - process, interview, ties, status, and FAQs

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

What the B-2 visa is - and isn't

The B-2 is a nonimmigrant visa for temporary visits to the United States for tourism, vacation, visiting family or friends, or certain medical treatment. It does not permit employment of any kind, enrollment in a formal course of study (occasional recreational classes are generally fine; a degree program is not), or an intent to stay permanently. It's frequently combined with business purposes as a B-1/B-2 visa - if you'll also attend meetings or a conference, say so; it doesn't weaken a tourism case.

The process end to end

Step	What happens
1. DS-160	Complete the online application at ceac.state.gov . Keep your confirmation barcode.
2. Pay the visa fee	Pay the nonimmigrant visa application (MRV) fee through the method your local embassy/consulate specifies - usually before you can book an interview.
3. Schedule appointments	Book your interview (and biometrics/fingerprinting appointment where the post requires a separate one) through the scheduling portal for your country.
4. Gather documents	Passport, DS-160 confirmation, appointment letter, photo if required in person, plus supporting evidence - see the Document Checklist.
5. Attend the interview	Typically brief (often a few minutes). A consular officer reviews your case and decides on the spot in most instances.
6. Wait for the visa / passport return	If approved, your passport is returned with the visa stamp, usually within a matter of days, though this varies by post.

The interview

Most B-2 interviews are short - often just a couple of minutes once you reach the window. The officer isn't trying to trip you up; they're trying to quickly confirm the story your paperwork already tells. Typical questions include:

- What's the purpose of your trip, and how long will you stay?
- Who are you traveling with, or who will you be visiting?
- What do you do for work / study, and how long have you done it?
- Who is paying for the trip?
- Have you traveled internationally before? To the U.S. before?
- Do you have family in the United States?

Answer directly and briefly - long, over-explained answers can read as rehearsed or evasive. If you don't understand a question, it's fine to ask the officer to repeat it.

Ties to your home country, in depth

This is the single most important concept in the entire application. "Ties" are the things that would make leaving your home country costly or disruptive - and therefore make returning to it the obviously rational choice. Strong ties are usually a combination of:

- Employment - a stable job with a return-to-work expectation, ideally with a supervisor letter
- Family - a spouse, children, or dependents who remain at home while you travel
- Property or financial obligations - a home, a lease, an ongoing business
- Education - enrollment you're expected back for, with a return date

No single tie is required, and no single tie is automatically disqualifying if it's missing - officers weigh the whole picture. Younger applicants or those between jobs should focus on whichever ties genuinely apply to them rather than trying to manufacture ones that don't.

Visa validity vs. how long you can actually stay

This trips up a lot of first-time applicants. The visa itself (the stamp in your passport) only controls how long you're allowed to use it to request entry to the U.S. and for how many trips ("entries") - it does not set how long you can stay on any single visit. That's decided separately by the Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officer at your port of entry, recorded as your admitted-until date on your I-94 record (available at i94.cbp.dhs.gov). For B-2 visitors this is commonly up to six months per visit, at the officer's discretion - always go by the date on your actual I-94, not the visa's expiry date.

Extending your stay

If you need more time than your I-94 allows, you can file Form I-539 (Application to Extend/Change Nonimmigrant Status) before it expires. Filing does not guarantee approval, and staying past your authorized date without an approved extension is an overstay with real consequences for future visa applications - plan conservatively rather than assuming an extension will come through in time.

Frequently asked questions

Can I work on a B-2 visa?

No. Any form of paid employment, including remote work for a foreign employer performed while physically present in the U.S. in some interpretations, is outside the scope of B-2 status - check current guidance if this applies to you.

Can I study on a B-2 visa?

Short recreational courses are generally fine; enrolling in a full course of study leading to a degree or certificate is not permitted on B-2 status.

Do I need a return ticket to apply?

It's not a strict legal requirement to have one booked at the DS-160/interview stage, but having a clear, plausible return plan strengthens your case either way.

What if I'm refused?

Most refusals are under INA 214(b) and aren't permanent - see the Visa Refusal Decision Guide for how to approach a reapplication.